

POL 101: FINAL PROJECT

Bangladesh: A Democratic Reconstruction

Analyzing Historical Development, Institutions, and Indicators (2026 Edition)

Spring Semester 2026 | Section 18

| Presentation Roadmap



Theoretical Framework

Applying theories of Nationalism, Democracy, and Authoritarianism to the Bangladeshi context.



Historical Development

From the Language Movement of 1952 to the "Monsoon Revolution" of 2024.



Democratic Indicators

A deep dive into the Freedom House 2026 scorecard and recent constitutional reforms.



Current Evaluation

Assessing the success of the 2026 General Election and future governance challenges.

| Nationalism & The Foundational Spark

1952

Language Movement: The birth of cultural nationalism and demand for recognition.

1971

Liberation War: The "Political and National unit" become congruent (Gellner).

1990

Anti-Autocracy: Student-led movement restores the parliamentary democracy.

2024

Monsoon Revolution: Dismantling the 15-year hybrid-regime and "Fear Barrier".

Nationalism Theory: Benedict Anderson's "Imagined Communities" found its peak in 1971, where shared language and trauma forged a sovereign identity.

| The Authoritarian Consolidation

2009 – 2024: A Hybrid Regime

- **Coercive Apparatus:** Leveraging military and police for political repression (Bellin).
- **Institutional Capture:** Systematic dismantling of the Caretaker Government system in 2011.
- **Rentier Characteristics:** Control over economic resources to fund patronage networks.
- **Political Monopoly:** Three consecutive illegitimate elections (2014, 2018, 2024).



The Monsoon Revolution

The Breaking of the Fear Barrier

In July 2024, a student-led uprising over job quotas transformed into a mass movement against authoritarianism.

Key Drivers: Long-standing grievances, social media mobilization, and the "Impunity" of the ruling elite reached a breaking point.

The regime fell because the military eventually withdrew its support from the autocrat—a classic Bellin outcome.



| Freedom House 2026 Scorecard

44

/ 100 Total Score

Status: **Partly Free**

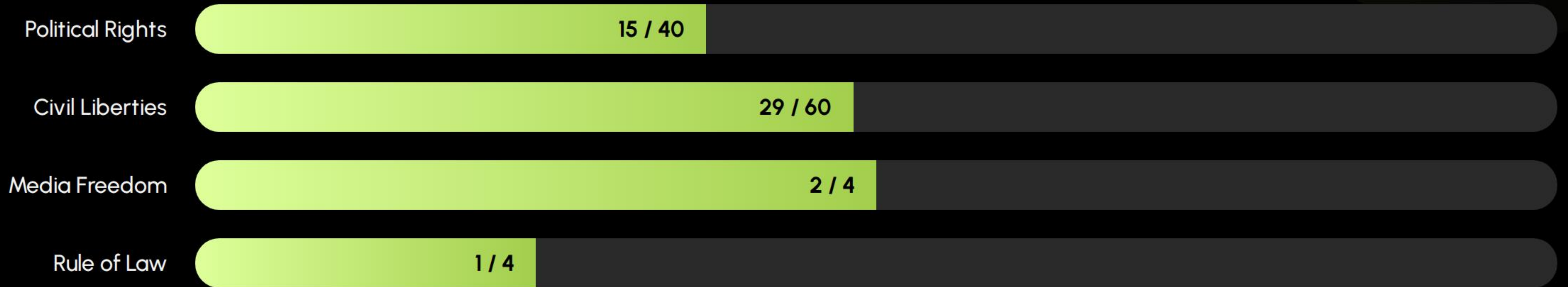
Historical Trend

The 2026 score marks a recovery from the 2024 lows, reflecting the reopening of political and civic space.

Global Context

Bangladesh now outperforms many regional autocracies but trails behind stable democracies like Canada.

| Democratic Indicators Breakdown



Note: Rule of Law remains the most critical vulnerability due to "extralegal violence" and political retribution in 2025.

| Analysis of Political Rights



Electoral Process

The Feb 2026 election saw the first competitive polls in a decade, but the AL ban raises pluralism concerns.



Political Pluralism

Return of BNP and restoration of Jamaat-e-Islami have created a diverse, if polarized, opposition.



Functioning Govt

Interim government (2025) successfully reformed state institutions before the transition to elected rule.

| The Role of the Judiciary



Restoring Independence

In September 2025, a landmark High Court ruling struck down executive amendments, ensuring the Supreme Court controls lower court appointments.

This "Constitutional Choice" is designed to prevent judicial co-option by any future ruling party, a key lesson from the Hasina era.

2026 Constitutional Reforms

Reform Category	Status	Description
Executive System	Parliamentary	PM accountable to House; Two-term limit introduced.
Legislative System	Bicameral	New Upper House (Senate) for inclusive consensus.
Electoral System	Mixed/Referendum	Caretaker system permanently constitutionalized.
Civil Rights	CSO 2025	Cyber Security Ordinance replaces the draconian CSA.

| Current Governance Context

The 2026 General Election was not an end, but a beginning. The success of our democracy now depends on constitutional legitimacy over revolutionary fervor.

— Reflection on the July Charter Reforms

Key Threat: Populism

The danger of new leaders claiming "only we represent the people," leading 60% of the population to distrust the government.

Key Strength: Adaptation

The transition from Majoritarianism to Consensus Democracy, leading 60% of the population to support the government.

Thank You

Critical Analysis of Bangladesh's Democratic Transition (2026)



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| Image Sources



<https://newsandletters.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/08/Bangladesh-students-protest-1024x683.jpg>

Source: newsandletters.org



https://insights.som.yale.edu/sites/default/files/styles/max_2600x2600/public/2024-09/Bangladesh%20Monsoon%20Revolution.jpg?itok=_H3l8V7y

Source: insights.som.yale.edu



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Source: [www.litonpublication.com](http://litonpublication.com)



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Source: en.wikipedia.org
